

The Cognitive–Developmental Approach to Coaching

Tatiana Bachkirova

INTRODUCTION

The cognitive–developmental approach is based on research studies that suggest that people differ in ways that could not be explained by personality types, learning styles or personal preferences, all of which are usually seen as relatively stable for each individual. This approach suggests that people differ not only from other people but also undergo significant changes in themselves, for example in the way they make meaning of their experiences. The changes of these capacities occur in a logical sequence of stages throughout the life of the individual. They influence the depth and complexity of what each individual can notice and therefore operate on and change. This development can be further stimulated and facilitated by appropriate support and challenge within the coaching process. Understanding developmental trajectories may help coaches to be better equipped to address the diverse needs of their clients.

This chapter opens with a short history of the approach; it is followed by a discussion of its main assumptions and suggested applications for coaching. It will be compared with other theoretical traditions useful for coaching. Examples will be provided for applying this approach to different coaching contexts and genres with an evaluation made of its strengths and limitations.

A brief history of the tradition

Three major areas of research gave rise to principal strands within this approach.

- The first strand began with the important work of Jean Piaget (1976). It emphasizes developmental changes in reasoning and meaning-making which extend, for example to moral reasoning (Kohlberg, 1969); intellectual

development (Perry, 1970); reflective judgment (King & Kitchener, 1994); and 'orders of mind' (Kegan, 1982, 1994).

- The second strand is ego-development, with its origins in the research of Jane Loevinger (1976, 1987). It focuses on the development of self-identity and the maturity of interpersonal relationships and has been further extended to include post-autonomous ego development by Cook-Greuter (1999, 2004) and action logics by Torbert (1991); Torbert & Associates (2004).
- The foundation of the third strand is the research of Clare Graves (1970) into levels of existence, which was later extended into 'worldviews' and 'values' by Beck and Cowan (1996) and is known as 'Spiral Dynamics'.

There are other theories and research findings that suggest that other aspects of personal development also occur in sequential stages, for example, emotions (Goleman, 1995), needs (Maslow, 1954) and spiritual awareness (Fowler, 1981). These aspects will be called here 'developmental lines' as suggested by Wilber (1999). All these studies are conducted in the tradition of developmental structuralism, which looks for patterns that connect specific psychological phenomena. According to this approach, individual characteristics are emergent, coming into being in a predictable and sequential way.

The continuing contribution of Ken Wilber (1999, 2000, 2006) to this approach is difficult to overestimate. He pulls together many theories and research findings relevant to this approach, creating a compelling picture of integral individual development that incorporates a range of developmental lines. Discussing the findings of these studies, he emphasizes various milestones of growth and development in each developmental line, calling them 'stages of consciousness'. With each successive stage or level the qualities of the previous stage remain as properties of the new stage. Therefore, with each new stage, a person can use anything learned in a previous stage and so becomes more flexible, integrated and more capable of functioning within a changing world that is also becoming more complex.

MAIN CONCEPTS AND ASSUMPTIONS

Each of the above studies identifies different stages in the developmental lines they study. As in map making, the way to divide and represent the territory is somewhat arbitrary – it is not important 'how you slice and dice development' (Wilber, 2006).

However, some common patterns can be identified in the various ways suggested for 'slicing the developmental pie'. According to one of the patterns, development proceeds from the 'pre-conventional level', which is simple and is focused only on the needs of the ego, to the 'conventional', which could be seen as focused on the individual's environment and the people who are close to them. It then proceeds to the 'post-conventional level', which is more complex and includes 'concern about the whole world'.

Stages take considerable time to develop and cannot be 'skipped', because each is built upon the previous one, and in a particular way. Wilber (2006) calls this '*holarchy*', which is similar to the relationship between atoms, molecules, cells and whole organisms. Holarchy implies that it is not possible to go from atoms to cells 'skipping' molecules. Each developmental line

(cognitive, emotional, moral, etc.) is unfolding in the same way but at a different pace for each particular person. This means that someone could be, for example, at the highest stage intellectually, the lowest stage morally and somewhere in the middle interpersonally.

This, of course, makes the topic of overall development of individuals very complex. Wilber suggests that

although substantial empirical evidence demonstrates that each line develops through these holarchical stages in an invariant sequence, nonetheless, because all two dozen of them develop relatively independently, overall growth and development is a massively complex, overlapping, nonlinear affair, following no set sequence whatsoever. (Wilber, 1999: 291–2)

Figure 9.1 represents a snapshot in time of how an individual's development might look if we were able to measure each developmental line.

This representation, however abstract and tentative, could be useful in dispelling the myths of the simplicity of categorizing people and the validity of quick conclusions about their overall level of development. This may also indicate the futility of attempts to use one line for describing the level of development in another.

At the same time representations of developmental lines, whether linear or spiral, create a natural curiosity about the relationship between the lines: which line is more 'important'? Is there a central line or is there one yardstick against which all of them could be measured? Cook-Greuter (1999), for example, makes a case for an essential connection between the cognitive and ego-development lines, because 'it is the ego whose main function is to generate

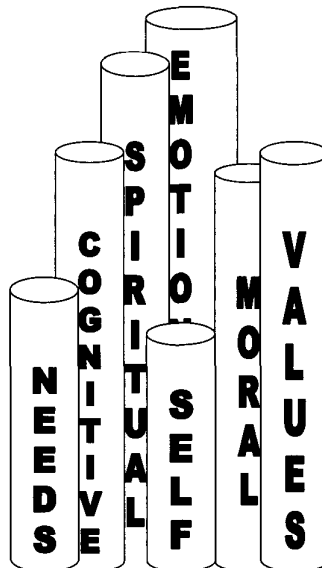


Figure 9.1 Example of a combination of the developmental lines in an individual.

coherent meaning’ (Cook-Greuter, 1999: 14). Some of the researchers who studied particular developmental lines assumed that theirs was the central characteristic of individual growth (Wilber, 2000).

There are also a number of controversies about the role of the cognitive line. Wilber (2006), for example, describes several propositions that attempt to explain the role of cognition in relation to all other lines. One of them suggests that the cognitive line could be a special one. Growth in the cognitive line is necessary but not sufficient for growth in other lines. After all, one has to be aware of something in order to act on it, need it, value it, etc. Another explanation suggests that the yardstick is consciousness *itself*. If consciousness is defined as ‘the degree of openness or emptiness’ it could be said to serve as the ‘shared altitude’ along which all development lines move. As such it is not a line itself but a ‘space’ in which lines arise and the ‘more phenomena in that line that *can* arise in consciousness, the higher the level in that line’ (Wilber, 2006: 68).

It is important to notice that Wilber defines cognition as ‘the capacity to take perspectives’. He even suggests that cognitive development could be measured in terms of the number of others with whom you can identify and the number of perspectives you can take. This again creates a parallel between consciousness and cognitive development. With this wider understanding of cognition, the description of this approach as ‘cognitive–developmental’ could legitimately stay as such, in spite of its apparent focus on only one developmental line. This is also the reason why Kegan’s (1982) theory, which explores ‘orders of mind’ and represents a cognitive developmental line, is a good one to use in this chapter as an example of the cognitive–developmental approach in the context of coaching.

GOALS AND TASKS OF THIS THEORY/TRADITION

It is important to notice that cognitive–developmental theories were not developed for coaching or any other kind of developmental intervention. The purpose of the research behind them was to:

- understand human nature
- explain the differences between people
- describe what constitutes ‘development’ when significant changes in individuals are noticed
- design measures for identifying the stages of development in individuals.

The task of influencing these kinds of changes was secondary. It could even be said that the idea of actively influencing development is contentious with some different authors. In my view the main goal of the cognitive–developmental approach, as in fact of any other approach to coaching, is to facilitate the process of making specific changes that are chosen by the client. For example psychological support is very important when an individual is facing transition or a new developmental task and that is what all coaches are aiming to provide.

What ‘a developmentally-minded’ coach may bring into this and what is crucial for the quality of this support is, according to Kegan, a presence of someone ‘who can see, recognise, and understand who the person is and who he or she is *becoming*’ (Kegan, 1982: 260) (emphasis added).

At the same time and in some specific cases, when clients have an explicit interest in a wider task of overall individual development, cognitive–developmental coaches are better placed than others to support them. In order to do this:

- It is useful to identify what developmental lines are the most important for the coaching task and where along the continuum of these lines a person may be.
- Coaches have to be sufficiently aware of the mechanism of change and transition between the stages in order to provide the client with appropriate support and challenge.
- Coaches have to be aware of their own stages of development in order to reflect on their own role in the coaching process and the dynamics of the coaching relationship.

The knowledge of this approach is also important for coaches because it draws attention to their own development and enriches their capacity for reflection and effective interaction with others. With each new stage they reach they become more capable of taking a number of perspectives on situations and of understanding more people (Bachkirova & Cox, 2007). They are, thereby, able to articulate, influence and change more critical situations in the coaching process.

Kegan’s theory and specific features of the coaching process

Kegan’s theory suggests that, as human beings, we have two tendencies that are rarely in perfect balance. The first is to differentiate ourselves from the environment and others, to be autonomous. The second tendency is to be included, to belong. The adaptive requirement of human nature is to pursue both differentiation and integration. Therefore the development of any organism is a balancing act in which one constantly negotiates ‘the self’ in relation to ‘the other’. At the same time, within oneself, there is a continuous process of recognizing and differentiating elements of self that were previously so integral to the self that they could not be noticed. The shift from what is perceived to be self (subject) to something that can be seen as elements of self (object) allows a new way of differentiating oneself from and relating to others. It could be said that these shifts initiate new ways of seeing the world, oneself and other people, creating new opportunities for autonomy and relatedness.

Before we discuss the important periods of relative stability (that Kegan calls ‘orders of mind’) between the shifts, it is useful to give some examples of the mechanism of change from subject to object, because it is an important process that coaching can usefully influence.

Things that are Subject in Kegan’s theory can prompt us to action but cannot be observed or reflected on. We cannot stand back and take a look at them because we are embedded in them. On the other hand, things that are Object for us are ‘those elements of our knowing or organizing that we can reflect on, handle, look at, be responsible for, relate to each other, take control of, internalize, assimilate, or otherwise operate upon’ (Kegan, 1994: 32). It has been said that

to be Subject is to 'see with' rather than to 'see through' (Drath, 1990). A good example is 'cultural blindness' as described by Drath (1990: 486), who suggests that

we see with our culture-bound norms and expectations, accept them as given, and cannot examine them for what they are – that is, we cannot see through them. Our cultural heritage is something we are, not something we have. The culture holds us; we are embedded in it and cannot rise above it.

A cognitive–developmental shift, however, is possible when we become aware of culturally determined differences and the distance they create from others. Such understanding could make cultural influences an Object, opening up new ways of seeing ourselves and of relating to others.

It is natural, therefore, that the more individuals can take as Object, the more complex their worldview becomes, because they can examine and act upon more things. The mechanism of the shift from Subject to Object could be considered as an essential element of coaching. It is one of the functions of coaches to watch for the re-absorption of insight in the client and to help build *psychological muscle* in order to hold something out from a person as an Object. As Berger and Fitzgerald (2002: 31) say: 'one of the most powerful interventions coaches can provide is simply help to keep critical insights alive for their clients'.

Here is an example from the coaching process. In his new role of head of department a client received feedback suggesting that his way of one-to-one communication with people made some of his staff uncomfortable. He asked his coach to help him to respond to this feedback, which he found puzzling. They explored this feedback together with the coach's own observations of his interactions with her and others. It appeared that the coachee's style involved unusually long pauses that people perceived as withdrawals. These apparently made those colleagues who were more self-conscious than others feel insecure. The client was not aware of this. His style was so much a part of who he was that he could not reflect on the effect of it on other people. As the result of coaching, his style from being Subject has gradually changed into Object, leading to the client's increased ability to notice it and modify it when necessary.

Kegan (1982) suggests that the shift from subject to object happens in relation to some crucially important elements of self in a similar way to the above example. When this happens it leads to a significant change in people, transforming the way they make meaning of their experience and how they relate to other people. He calls the five periods between these significant changes 'Orders of Mind' through which people evolve. Table 9.1 is created mainly on the basis of his work (1982) with additional contributions from further research and publications by Berger and Fitzgerald (2002) and Cook-Greuter (1999).

Kegan (1982) advocates that the development process is a combination of internal and external factors for each individual, but can be stimulated and facilitated by appropriate support and challenge, for example from within the coaching process. Even if development is not an explicit agenda for the coaching engagement, Berger and Fitzgerald (2002) claim that the cognitive–developmental approach has much to offer, particularly with regard to issues of mismatch between the complexity that the client role may require and his/her own order of mind. They suggest different strategies for supporting clients when there is such a misfit.

Table 9.1: Five stages of development according to Kegan's theory

Stage	Subject	Object	Cognitive style	Self	Others	Conscious preoccupation	Inclusion/separation balance
1	Impulses, perceptions	Reflections (sensing, moving)	Pre-operational simplicity	Emerging ego through ownership of what is 'mine'	Exist for fulfilment of their needs	Safety and gratification of basic needs	More of inclusion
Children act on impulse. They are subject to perceptions, so if perception changes the world also changes. They cannot imagine that others may have different opinions of the same things. They cannot hold ideas in their mind for long and need to be reminded of the rules.							
2	Needs, interests, wishes	Impulses, perceptions	Concrete operational, black and white thinking	Single concrete features, emergence of 'agent', 'I am what I want'	Competing for goods and power, and can see through me	Gaining advantages and protecting oneself	More of separation
With the ability to control impulses comes a sense of freedom and power, therefore those at this stage are now synonymous with their needs and wishes. They can see that others also have wishes and interests that may clash with theirs. They feel that they have to protect themselves and are concerned with power over them. They are self-centred and see others as helpers or barriers to getting what they want and follow rules mostly to avoid punishment.							
3	The interpersonal, mutuality	Needs, interests, wishes	Ability for abstract thinking and self-reflection	Self is defined in terms of internalized expectations of important others	Others are divided on the inner circle who provide values and identity and those who are outside it	Social acceptance, status and prestige, moral 'shoulds and oughts'	More of inclusion
At this stage the person <i>has</i> needs, not <i>is</i> his/her needs, so others are understood as also having needs. They are no longer a means to his/her ends and can subordinate their needs to something greater. However, they <i>are</i> now their relationship. Expectations of others are so important that this may cause difficulties in making decisions and give rise to issues of self-esteem. They may feel torn apart by the conflict between important others. Kegan believes that people in the Third order feel 'in over their heads' much of the time.							

4	Authorship, identity, psychic administration, ideology	The interpersonal, mutuality	Can see multiplicity and patterns, critical and analytical	Strong ego with interest in deep self-understanding. Awareness of self-deception	Capable of understanding others and of having true empathy. Can build meaningful relationships	Achievement of long-term personal goals according to inner standards. Pursuit of truth	More of separation
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A person at this stage is someone who now *has* the relationship. This implies a self that may exist outside of relationship with others, with a sense of autonomy and identity. People at this stage are able to examine various rules and opinions and mediate between them. They can feel empathy for others and take their views into consideration, but at the same time are not torn apart by the views of others – they have their own system with which to make decisions. They are self-motivated, self-evaluative. They can create their own rules and fight for them but may not be the best diplomats, because their way of doing things may be too important to them.

5	Inter-individuality, inter-penetrability of self-systems	Authorship, identity, psychic administration, ideology	Systems view and meaning-making as interpretation. Tolerance of ambiguity. Change from linear logic to holistic understanding	Integration of all aspects of self including shadow. Capacity for interdependent self-definition	Others are also self-systems. Respect for uniqueness and development	Individuality and self-fulfilment. Immediate present. Intense relationship	More of inclusion
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At this stage a person becomes someone who *has* identity and can explore his/her own self-system. Learning about the limitations of their own inner system they recognize the limitation of *having* an inner system. Looking across their inner systems they can see similarities in what look like differences. They are less prone to black and white thinking and apply fewer dichotomies and polarities in their evaluations of the world.

Here is an example of how a coach may support a client at a Third order of mind whose role has Fourth order expectations. This coaching engagement may easily take place if the client has been successful in a previous role and is promoted to a new, more complex one. It could also happen because of a change in the nature of the job or with a request from a boss who wants the client to take more responsibility for decision making or for the ownership of the process. The client may feel overwhelmed by these expectations. He may have the abilities to meet the demands, but the Fourth order complexity of his new role may require him to evaluate and prioritize these demands without the guidance of a third party. The client may be strained and resentful towards his boss for not providing him with enough direction. The boss, on the other hand, being at the Fourth order of mind, expects the client to take the initiative and becomes frustrated with him when he is reluctant to do so.

Berger and Fitzgerald (2002) suggest that a developmentally-oriented coach can support a client at the Third order of mind by, for example:

- helping to identify and articulate the expectations that are causing strain and confusion
- exploring with the client what sources of information or judgment might be available to support their decision making
- helping the client to craft a decision-making process
- identifying ways to have constructive discussions with bosses and/or peers
- reframing any sense of defeat and failure that the client might feel into a developmental opportunity.

This approach allows the coach to recognize the specific challenges of clients who are moving towards a different level of complexity. For example the challenge for people changing from the Third to the Fourth order is to question the infallibility of external guides and to trust their internal, self-authored guide. However, the challenge of people who move from the Fourth to the Fifth order, in contrast, is to question the infallibility of their own self-authored system and to help them see the need to transcend their reliance on their own system (Berger & Fitzgerald, 2002). Berger (2006) also suggests ways of identifying key strengths, blind spots and areas of growth for clients at each stage, and comments on pitfalls that coaches may face with these client groups.

It has to be said that the cognitive–developmental approach is also known for the complexity of its theory and particularly for its labour-intensive measurements used to identify developmental stages. Lahey and associates (1988) developed the subject–object interview (SOI), which is used for the assessment of 21 gradations within Kegan’s orders of mind. It requires 60-90 minutes of recorded interview and a highly skilful scoring of the transcript. There is also the Washington University Sentence Completion Test used to measure Loevinger’s (1976) stages, which has been updated by Cook-Greuter (2004) as the Leadership Development Profile (LDP). Laske (2006a, 2006b) uses SOI together with some additional instruments for the assessment of the development of coaches.

The cognitive–developmental approach does not imply the use of specific tools and techniques of coaching or counselling. It implies careful consideration of the appropriateness of all tools and techniques that different approaches might offer to each level of development

of clients. The actual helping process could be described as an artful balance of support and challenge appropriate for each stage of development. The crucial part of it is the active engagement of all skills and abilities of developmentally-minded coaches in addressing the work and life tasks of their clients. This approach also emphasizes the importance of the personal growth of practitioners themselves (Bachkirova & Cox, 2007). It is the coach as a person, rather than the application of particular techniques or methods, that makes a difference in coaching practice.

COMPARING THIS THEORY/TRADITION

This approach differs from others in terms of its main philosophical assumption about human nature. Traditional psychoanalysis, for example takes a more sceptical view of human development at the individual and collective levels, while humanistic psychology works on the assumption of unlimited potential for the growth of each individual. According to the developmentalists an individual *may* progress through the various levels, but equally may go into reverse, while humanity itself is always moving forward.

The cognitive–developmental approach was not originally developed for counselling as were most other approaches. Therefore it has no stake in claiming any particular psychological ‘territory’ as, for example cognitive-behavioural or transpersonal approaches do. Instead, development can be seen from any angle (emotional, rational, behavioural, etc.) and any other approach to coaching is valued as contributing to the overall developmental process.

At the same time it could be said that the focus of this approach is on vertical rather than horizontal changes. The latter changes, such as in skills, performance, specific behaviours and level of confidence, can occur as a result of coaching or just through exposure to life. However valuable these changes are, not all of them will contribute to the developmental shifts in which this approach is interested. In his earlier writings, Wilber (1979) suggested that some psychotherapeutic approaches are better suited than others to the issues that particular developmental stages may deal with, indicating a sort of ladder of therapies. This logic may be similarly applied to coaching approaches.

RELATIONSHIP WITH CONTEXTS AND GENRES OF COACHING

There is an obvious connection between the cognitive–developmental approach and *developmental coaching*, which is concerned with holistic changes in the person. If clients are dealing with important dilemmas or transitions in their lives (a theme that often occurs in developmental coaching) the cognitive–developmental perspective may help coaches and clients to understand that this transition may be not just an adjustment to the environmental changes but also an internal process that has specific features. This can be helpful for clients as it will

help them to understand what they are going through and to see the specific landmarks of this process.

For *transformational coaching* some specific pointers may be given from the cognitive developmental perspective as to what may constitute a transformation and under what circumstances it is likely to happen. The cognitive–developmental approach may offer a different explanation of the state of being ‘stuck’ and of why the coach may not be able to promote a transformation in the client. Clients who appear stuck in the Third order may have a need to stay attached to an important group or organization and may refuse to question anything that shakes their belief system. Other clients may be stuck in the Fourth order of mind because they feel comfortable, confident and in control in their lives there. The cognitive developmental approach may also be useful when there is a need to integrate a person’s transformational experience with a relevant self-frame or worldview. Very often these experiences fade because there is no framework that offers ‘order’, ‘explanation’, a sense of progression – in short, a meaning – to their experiences.

In relation to *team coaching*, this approach makes clear why group work is sometimes difficult. For example when individuals, at different levels of development, are intensely involved in the same process, the chances of serious misunderstandings are numerous. However, opportunities for expected and unexpected growth may also be present. Cognitive developmental theories may help to explain the reasons for disagreements and conflicts. They may also help coaches to find an overall perspective which allows for the integration of the different needs of individuals into the value system of the team.

The coach’s own level of development is also important. To be most help to the client the coach should be able to recognize where the client is on the developmental line. As has been said already, people find difficulty in recognizing levels of development higher than their own and consequently may not be optimally helpful as coaches in such cases. At the same time it could be argued that within certain coaching genres, for example skills coaching, such a discrepancy is less important.

EVALUATION OF THE APPROACH AND CONCLUSIONS

For the evaluation of this approach I would like to consider two aspects of it that cause unease in some coaches. There are also some warnings for those who might be overzealous in using this approach without sufficient appreciation of its complexity. Starting with the latter, it is important to emphasize that the nature of development as discussed in this chapter is a complex process that involves a combination of known and unknown, internal and environmental factors. The shift from one stage to another may even take years to be noticed and recognized. In addition, the theory, once understood, may be so attractive to some coaches that it seduces them into using it inappropriately, designing and suggesting interventions to ‘move’ clients from one stage to another. The main danger of this approach is that it may create the illusion that significant

developmental shifts can be induced by sufficient motivation and effort. It may also distract coaches from attending to other concerns of the client which may actually be more relevant to them and have greater urgency.

Therefore, I would agree with Berger's warning about hasty judgments of developmental stages, particularly in organizational contexts (2006) and about simplistic interpretations of this theoretical perspective. A useful reminder of this is also the following concern of Kegan himself: 'amongst the many things from which a practitioner's clients need protection is the practitioner's hopes for the client's future, however benign and sympathetic these hopes may be' (1982: 295).

At the same time, we do see again and again that the coaching process, even if it aims at specific and pragmatic goals, provides important conditions for potential developmental shifts in individuals. By engaging with the presenting task, coaches inevitably evaluate a fit between the existing capabilities of the client and the complexity of a task. This prompts them to create appropriate conditions for a developmental shift if necessary and it may well happen. However, coaching engagements do not need to aim at such shifts to be successful. Coaching is an ideal means through which to facilitate individual development in all shapes and forms.

Keeping in mind this positive stance, let us address the point of unease that coaches sometimes express in relation to this approach. They are concerned that it implies a judgment about the level of development that a client or coach represents in their behaviour, going against an implicit characteristic of coaching as non-judgmental. This is a sensitive and complex issue which needs to be considered carefully.

Yes, developmental approaches, by the very fact of presenting developmental scales, imply judgments, but similar judgments are made on an everyday basis for all sorts of reasons which are fairly justified. What has to be taken into consideration is the purpose of the judgment and the validity of it. The purpose of judgment in coaching is to facilitate a better fit between the environment and the individual's capacity for dealing with it, which is done in the best service of the client. The validity of the judgment is based on the quality of the theory and supporting data, which is impressive, but also on the quality of the actual assessment.

This leaves us with the second point of unease related to the issue of instruments of assessment for coaching needs. In order to know the stage of development of the client, coaches seem to have two options. One obvious option is to use independent assessments of the client's stage through specific instruments such as the SOI or LDP, which are available, but quite expensive additions to the coaching itself. If coaches are hoping to add such instruments to their tool kits, they have to be aware that they are complex and time-consuming, particularly for scoring and interpretation. It is also advisable to know that, in spite of the reasonable inter-rater reliability amongst highly trained scorers, which is statistically sufficient for research purposes, the probability of error in individual cases is still high.

Another assessment option is for the coach to rely on an 'educated guess'. However imperfect it may sound I would not dismiss and may even advocate this option if at least two conditions are fulfilled. The first condition is that the coach is developmentally-minded and sufficiently knowledgeable of this approach to recognize the meaning-making that the client is applying to

various themes, even if the coach makes this judgment ‘on behalf of one stage over another’ (Kegan, 1982: 292). The second condition is that the coach him/herself is constantly and actively engaged in the developmental process and, ideally, is further along the line of development than the client.

Why do I believe that such judgment is better for coaching than relying on formal instruments? First of all, the coach’s judgment of the client’s stage will then remain a tentative one and they will not necessarily voice it. (With the use of instruments the temptation to see their results as ‘truth’ is much higher.) Second, in my view, coaching is valuable when coaches give respectful attention to the voices of *all* the client’s states and stages and not only to ‘the centre of developmental gravity’. Having a healthy doubt about the client’s stage would help to keep the coach’s attention fresh and open to these voices. And, finally, I believe that a place for a grain of mystery should be always kept in coaching, which is, to some extent, as much a mysterious process as the development itself.

FURTHER READING

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- Cook-Greuter, S. (2004). Making the case for developmental perspective. *Industrial and Commercial Training*, 36(7). (Very clear and comprehensive article that explains the main tenets and applications of the approach to an organizational world.)
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